

Essay Writing

- 
- An essay is generally a short piece of writing outlining the writer's perspective or story. It is often considered synonymous with a story or a paper or an article. Essays can be formal as well as informal. Formal essays are generally academic in nature and tackle serious topics.

How to write an effective Essay

- Three parts:
- 1. Brainstorming
- 2. Making Outlines
- 3. Actual Writing

Steps to Writing an Essay

- **Read and understand the topic:** Know exactly what is being asked of you. It's a good idea to dissect the topic into parts.
- **Plan:** Brainstorming and organizing your ideas will make your life much easier when you go to write your essay. It's a good idea to make a web of your ideas and supporting details.
- **Use and cite sources:** Do your research. Use quotes and paraphrase from your sources, but NEVER plagiarize.
- **Write a Draft:** write your first draft.

- 
- **Make a strong thesis:** The thesis (main argument) of the essay is the most important thing you'll write. Make it a strong point.
 - **Respond to the topic:** Once you have worked out any kinks in your draft, you can start writing the final draft of your essay.
 - **Proofread:** Read your response carefully to make sure that there are no mistakes and that you didn't miss anything.
 - However, every essay assignment is different and it's important to be mindful of that. If one of these steps isn't applicable to the essay you are writing, skip it and move to the next one.

A typical Essay

- Paragraph 1: Introduction
- Paragraph 2: Body 1
- Paragraph 3: Body 2
- Paragraph 4: Body 3
- Paragraph 5: Conclusion

The Introduction

- The principle purpose of the introduction is to present your position (this is also known as the "thesis" or "argument") on the issue at hand but effective introductory paragraphs are so much more than that. Before you even get to this thesis statement, for example, the essay should begin with a "hook" that grabs the reader's attention and makes them want to read on. Examples of effective hooks include relevant quotations ("no man is an island") or surprising statistics ("three out of four doctors report that...").
- Only then, with the reader's attention "hooked," should you move on to the thesis. The thesis should be a clear, one-sentence explanation of your position that leaves no doubt in the reader's mind about which side you are on from the beginning of your essay.

- Following the thesis, you should provide a mini-outline which previews the examples you will use to support your thesis in the rest of the essay. Not only does this tell the reader what to expect in the paragraphs to come but it also gives them a clearer understanding of what the essay is about.
- Finally, designing the last sentence in this way has the added benefit of seamlessly moving the reader to the first paragraph of the body of the paper. In this way we can see that the basic introduction does not need to be much more than three or four sentences in length. If yours is much longer you might want to consider editing it down a bit!

The Body Paragraphs

- The middle paragraphs of the essay are collectively known as the body paragraphs and, as alluded to above, the main purpose of a body paragraph is to spell out in detail the examples that support your thesis.
- For the first body paragraph you should use your strongest argument or most significant example unless some other more obvious beginning point (as in the case of chronological explanations) is required. The first sentence of this paragraph should be the topic sentence of the paragraph that directly relates to the examples listed in the mini-outline of introductory paragraph.

- A Word on Transitions
- You may have noticed that, though the above paragraph aligns pretty closely with the provided outline, there is one large exception: the first few words. These words are example of a transitional phrase – others include "furthermore," "moreover," but also "by contrast" and "on the other hand" – and are the hallmark of good writing.
- Transitional phrases are useful for showing the reader where one section ends and another begins. It may be helpful to see them as the written equivalent of the kinds of spoken cues used in formal speeches that signal the end of one set of ideas and the beginning of another. In essence, they lead the reader from one section of the paragraph of another.

The Conclusion

- Although the conclusion paragraph comes at the end of your essay it should not be seen as an afterthought. As the final paragraph it represents your last chance to make your case and, as such, should follow an extremely rigid format.
- One way to think of the conclusion is, paradoxically, as a second introduction because it does in fact contain many of the same features. While it does not need to be too long – four well-crafted sentences should be enough – it can make or break an essay.
- Effective conclusions open with a concluding transition ("in conclusion," "in the end," etc.) and an allusion to the "hook" used in the introductory paragraph. After that you should immediately provide a restatement of your thesis statement.

- 
- Having done all of that, the final element – and final sentence in your essay – should be a "global statement" or "call to action" that gives the reader signals that the discussion has come to an end.

- 
- Taken together, then, the overall structure of a five paragraph essay should look something like this:
 - Introduction Paragraph
 - An attention-grabbing "hook"
 - A thesis statement
 - A preview of the three subtopics you will discuss in the body paragraphs.

- First Body Paragraph

- Topic sentence which states the first subtopic and opens with a transition
- Supporting details or examples
- An explanation of how this example proves your thesis

- Second Body Paragraph

- Topic sentence which states the second subtopic and opens with a transition
- Supporting details or examples
- An explanation of how this example proves your thesis

- Third Body Paragraph

- Topic sentence which states the third subtopic and opens with a transition
- Supporting details or examples
- An explanation of how this example proves your thesis

- Concluding Paragraph

- Concluding Transition, Reverse "hook," and restatement of thesis.
- Rephrasing main topic and subtopics.
- Global statement or call to action.

Types of Essays

- ***Narrative Essays:*** This is when the writer is narrating an incident or story through the essay. So these are in the first person. The aim when writing narrative essays is to involve the reader in them as if they were right there when it was happening. So make them as vivid and real as possible. One way to make this possible is to follow the principle of ‘show, don’t tell’. So you must involve the reader in the story.

- 
- ***Descriptive Essays:*** Here the writer will describe a place, an object, an event or maybe even a memory. But it is not just plainly describing things. The writer must paint a picture through his words. One clever way to do that is to evoke the senses of the reader. Do not only rely on sight but also involve the other senses of smell, touch, sound etc. A descriptive essay when done well will make the reader feel the emotions the writer was feeling at the moment.

- 
- ***Expository Essays:*** In such an essay a writer presents a balanced study of a topic. To write such an essay, the writer must have real and extensive knowledge about the subject. There is no scope for the writer's feelings or emotions in an expository essay. It is completely based on facts, statistics, examples etc.

- ***Persuasive Essays:*** Here the purpose of the essay is to get the reader to your side of the argument. A persuasive essay is not just a presentation of facts but an attempt to convince the reader of the writer's point of view. Both sides of the argument have to be presented in these essays. But the ultimate aim is to persuade the readers that the writer's argument carries more weight.

